



Bowl
1000–1199 • IRAN/IRAQ
The bold colors of this simple bowl are typically Islamic, as is the interlacing cord design. The lace of highlighted detail lends a meditative quality to the design.



Feline incense burner
11–12TH CENTURIES • IRAN/AFGHANISTAN
Burners like this, in the shape of a big cat, were used in the courts of Medieval Islamic kings—lions and cheetahs symbolized power. The head tilts to allow insertion of charcoal.



Candlestick
15TH CENTURY • MAMLUK EGYPT
To circumvent the prohibition on precious metals, Islamic metalworkers became adept at combining baser metals like brass with silver and gold inlay.



Qibla compass
DATE AND ORIGIN UNKNOWN
This ornamental compass was used to indicate the direction, *qibla*, of Mecca, so that worshippers could orient themselves properly for prayer.



Calligraphy scissors
1700–99 • IRAN
These scissors were used for shaping pens and brushes. The blades are inlaid with gold, a variety of damascening known as *koftgari*.



Islamic lamp
DATE AND ORIGIN UNKNOWN
This hourglass-shaped lamp bares a design of Arabic script on the side, which is picked out in vibrant blue, a ceramic dye perfected by Islamic craftsmen.

Pen case
1700–1899 • ORIGIN UNKNOWN
This hexagonal case for carrying pens bares geometric shapes, a typical feature of Islamic design.



bold colors and gold leaf



Arabic script inscribed with careful calligraphy

illuminations flout normal prohibitions

Illuminated Divan
1800–99 • INDIA
A Divan, or Diwan, is a collection or anthology of poems, inspired by ancient Persian poetry models. This illuminated Divan of the Persian poet Hafez from 19th-century India has typical Kashmiri painted lacquer covers.